Sriyash Poddar

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Education

University of Washington (UW) — Seattle, US
PhD Student in Computer Science & Engineering, GPA: 4.00/4.00, in progress — *Sept. 2023 – Present*
Advisors: Prof. Abhishek Gupta, Prof. Natasha Jaques

Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Kharagpur — Kharagpur, IN
M.Tech and B.Tech in Computer Science and Engineering, GPA: 9.4/10.0 — *Jul. 2018 – Sept. 2023*
Advisor: Prof. Partha P. Chakrabarti

Publications

[7] **Poddar S.**, Mottaghi R., Puig X., Chang M., Krantz J., Jaques N.†, Gupta A.† "Asymmetric On-Policy Distillation Learns In-Context Exploration", *under review at* NeurIPS 2026

[6] Teegavarapu P.*,**Poddar S.***, Qi R., Winston C., Khandelwal K., Onol A., Jaques N.†, Gupta A.† "Q-OIL: Optimistic Exploration in Learning from Human Interventions", *under review at* CoRL 2026

[5] **Poddar S.***, Wan Y.*, Ivison H., Gupta A.†, Jaques N.† "Personalizing Reinforcement Learning from Human Feedback with Variational Preference Learning", *Conference on Neural Information Processing Systems* (NeurIPS) (**spotlight**), 2024 [paper]

[4] **Poddar S.**, Mavrogiannis C., Srinivasa S. S. "From Crowd Motion Prediction to Robot Navigation in Crowds", *International Conference on Intelligent Robots and Systems* (IROS), 2023 [paper]

[3] Mavrogiannis C., Balasubramanian K., **Poddar S.**, Gandra A., Srinivasa S. S. "Winding Through: Crowd Navigation via Topological Invariance", *IEEE Robotics and Automation Letters* (RA-L), 2023 [paper]

[2] Anand T., Badjatiya P., **Poddar S.**, Subramanian J., Theocharous G., Balaji K. "Optimal sequential decision-making with changing action space", *US Patent App. 17/659,983* [paper]

[1] Mukherjee R., **Poddar S.***, Naik A.*, Dasgupta S., Ganguly N. "Understanding the Role of Affect Dimensions in Detecting Emotions from Tweets: Multi-task Approach", *International ACM SIGIR Conference on Research and Development in Information Retrieval*, 2021 [paper]

* equal contribution, † equal advising

Work & Research Experience

Graduate Research Assistant — Seattle, US
Paul G. Allen School of Computer Science & Engineering — *Sept. 2023 – Present*
- Real-world feedback learning and test-time exploration for efficient adaptation and improvement.
- Training foundational models using diverse human feedback.

Research Scientist Intern — Menlo Park, US
FAIR Embodiment & Actions, Meta — *June. 2025 – Jan 2026*
- Building agents that can solve partially observed tasks via in-context learning

Research Intern — Montreal, CA
Mila - Quebec AI Institute, Advisor: Prof. Sarath Chandar — *May 2022 - July 2022*
- Intrinsic motivation for handling non-stationarity in multi-agent reinforcement learning.

Visiting Undergraduate Researcher — Montreal, CA
University of Washington (UW), Advisor: Prof. Siddhartha Srinivasa — *Nov 2021 - Jan 2022*
- Model predictive control and human motion prediction for safe crowd navigation.

Maching Learning Research Intern — Noida, IN
Adobe Media and Data Science Research — *May 2021 – July 2021*
- Continual reinforcement learning in dynamic action spaces such as recommender systems.

Service and Outreach

Reviewer
ICLR, ICML, NeurIPS, ICRA, HRI, T-RO

Teaching Assistant — Seattle, US
CSE 599 - Social Reinforcement Learning — *Spring 2024*

Teaching Assistant — Kharagpur, IN
CS60077 - Reinforcement Learning — *Winter 2023*

Kharagpur Robosoccer Students Group — Kharagpur, IN
Humanoid Team Member — *April 2021 - April 2023*

Awards & Scholarships

CMMRS — Saarbrücken, DE
Received full funding to attend summer school at the Max Planck Institute in Germany. — *2022*

MITACS Globalink and DAAD-Wise
Awarded funding for research internships in Canada and Germany. — *2022*

IIT JEE
Among the top 0.1% out of 1M students in JEE-Advanced and Mains. — *2018*

KVPY Fellowship
Awarded the fellowship by the Department of Science & Technology, India. — *2018*